Sources of Power

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Corpus priority: Phase 2
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Purpose In This RAG Corpus

- A crucial counterbalance to bias-heavy frameworks because it takes expertise and intuition in real settings seriously.
- Foundational for naturalistic decision making under pressure, uncertainty, and incomplete information.
- Very useful for nuanced system design where not all fast judgment is treated as flawed.

Key Concepts And Retrieval Tags

- naturalistic_decision_making
- recognition_primed_decision_model
- intuition
- mental_simulation
- team_mind
- hyperrationality

Core Learnings

- Laboratory models can understate the strengths of experienced decision makers operating in real environments.
- Experts often do not compare many options; they recognize patterns, simulate likely outcomes, and act.
- Intuition can be grounded in experience rather than mysticism, especially in high-feedback domains.
- Mental simulation, leverage detection, and team coordination are practical cognitive strengths.
- Overcorrecting toward rigid analysis can be harmful when speed, context, and expertise matter.

Directions, Observations, And Implications

- Use for emergency, operational, military, clinical, and leadership scenarios involving time pressure and incomplete information.
- Retrieve it when users ask whether intuition should ever be trusted or when structured analysis may be too slow.
- Apply it to recommendations that distinguish novice intuition from expert recognition.
- Useful for designing a balanced copilot that respects both discipline and real-world expertise.

How This Can Be Applied In Decision Making

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How This Strengthens A Bias-Aware RAG System

- Helps the corpus avoid becoming one-sidedly anti-intuition.
- Supports richer guidance on when to slow down and when to trust practiced expert pattern recognition.
- Useful for AI-human collaboration design where systems should augment, not flatten, skilled human judgment.

Limitations And Cautions

- This dossier is synthesized from public descriptions and table-of-contents data rather than a full-text extract.
- The book is best used as a balancing source alongside bias and noise materials, not as a rebuttal to them.

Chapter-Wise Summary

- **Introduction**: Frames the need to study decision making in real environments rather than only in simplified laboratory tasks.
- **Chronicling the Strengths Used in Making Difficult Decisions**: Introduces the project of identifying cognitive strengths that practitioners use under pressure.
- **Learning from the Firefighters**: Shows how field observations reveal expert pattern recognition and practical judgment.
- **The Recognition-Primed Decision Model**: Presents the model in which experts recognize plausible actions rather than compare many formal options.
- **The Power of Intuition**: Explains intuition as experience-based pattern matching rather than mere guesswork.
- **The Power of Mental Simulation**: Shows how experts mentally rehearse likely outcomes to test whether a plan will work.
- **The Vincennes Shootdown**: Uses a major error case to show how pressure, misframing, and context can still derail judgment.
- **Mental Simulation and Decision Making**: Deepens the account of simulation as a practical reasoning tool under uncertainty.
- **The Power to Spot Leverage Points**: Examines how experts detect where small interventions can have outsized effects.
- **Nonlinear Aspects of Problem Solving**: Shows that real decision problems often do not unfold in neat analytic sequences.
- **The Power to See the Invisible**: Highlights the role of tacit knowledge and subtle cues that novices often miss.
- **The Power of Stories**: Explains how narratives can organize experience and help teams make sense of complex situations.
- **The Power of Metaphors and Analogues**: Shows how analogy supports understanding and rapid transfer of lessons across situations.
- **The Power to Read Minds**: Explores social understanding and anticipation of other actors inside coordinated decision work.

- **The Power of the Team Mind**: Examines shared understanding, coordination, and collective expertise in high-performance teams.
- **The Power of Rational Analysis and the Problem of Hyperrationality**: Argues for balance: formal analysis matters, but excessive dependence on it can become counterproductive.
- **Why Good People Make Poor Decisions**: Acknowledges that even skilled decision makers can fail under certain pressures and conditions.
- **Conclusions**: Pulls the lessons together into a broader account of expertise, intuition, and real-world judgment.

Source Notes

- Open Library summary (library_summary): https://openlibrary.org/books/OL21196907M/Sources_of_power
- Open Library table of contents (table_of_contents): https://openlibrary.org/books/OL26943668M/Sources_of_power
- JSTOR record (bibliographic_record): https://www.jstor.org/stable/j.ctt1v2xt08

RAG Ingestion Note

This document is intentionally written as a concise, retrieval-friendly synthesis rather than as a book review. It is designed to help the system retrieve named biases and decision failures, practical mitigation methods, organizational and AI-governance implications, and scenario-to-concept mappings for user prompts.